

ADOLESCENCE



Transition between
childhood and
adulthood

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Overview

Characteristics of adolescence
Physical development
Cognitive development
Social-emotional development

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Adolescence

Transitional period between childhood & adulthood (12-18 years)

Biological perspective

Marked by beginning of puberty (10... 11... 12...)

Environmental/cultural perspective

Depends on country/culture whether adolescence is considered separate developmental stage & what it means
Western societies – period to explore possible roles before commitment and identity achieved

Emerging adulthood 18-25

Why is this period between childhood and adulthood so extended?

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Adolescence

Remarkable biological changes

Relationships with parents take a different form – seek more independence

Relationships with peers/friends more intimate

Dating, romantic relationships, sexual exploration

More advanced thinking—more abstract, ideological, logical

Heightened interest in self and body image

More radical in how they look and behave as they explore options and test boundaries

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Nature of adolescence

Is it a turbulent life stage full of conflict, mood swings, and delinquent behaviour?

Or do most adolescents navigate this stage relatively smoothly?

Deficit vs strengths-based view of adolescence

What groups may find this stage more difficult?

Adolescents require opportunities and support from caring adults to become competent adults

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Group work

Discuss

- Do you have a strength based or deficit view of adolescence – is it a smooth or a troublesome time?

- The adolescence view in the media and public perception can be deficit based and portrays teenagers as troublesome. Does this align with your experiences / perceptions?

Discuss in groups and be ready to report back.

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Puberty

Puberty marks the beginning of adolescence **but** adolescence is more than puberty

Brain-neuroendocrine process

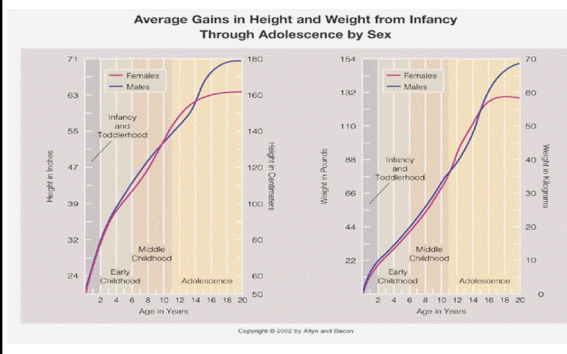
Rapid physical changes leading to maturation

Adult sized body

Attainment of sexual maturity

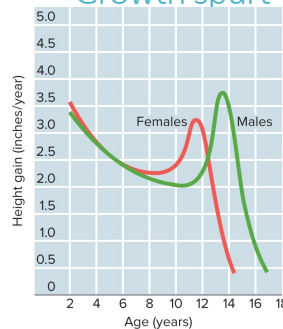
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Growth curve in adolescence



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Growth spurt



Rapid increase in height and weight - triggered by hormonal changes
Occurs 2 years earlier for girls than boys
Starts at 9-10 for girls; 11-12.5 for boys
Most pubertal change at 11.5 for girls & 13.5 for boys
Body growth complete by 16 for most girls; 17.5 for boys
In the end boys end up taller and heavier
Broader shoulders for boys; broader hips for girls
Boys gain more muscle strength; girls gain body fat associated with female figure
Much individual variation in timing
Ethnicity has an impact on body proportions & timing

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Sexual maturation

Hormonal changes – involving pituitary gland, hypothalamus, ovaries/testes (gonads)

Ovaries in girls produce **estradiol, a type of estrogen** – which influences body proportions & maturation of breasts, uterus, ovaries, & vagina

Testes in boys produce **testosterone, a type of androgen** – which leads to muscle growth, body & facial hair, & other male characteristics

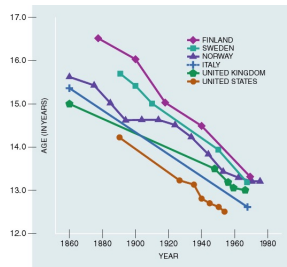
Primary sex characteristics - all the organs necessary for reproduction

Secondary sex characteristics - signs of sexual maturation that don't directly involve sex organs

Testosterone & estradiol present in both males & females; just one or the other are dominant

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Changing age of menarche



Secular trend - Reduction of 3-4 months per decade; may be plateauing

Due to better nutrition and health

Link with obesity

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Sequence of change

Girls - sexual maturity signaled by **menarche**, the first menstrual period at 12 to 13.5 on average

Follows beginning of breast growth, growth spurt, pubic & armpit hair

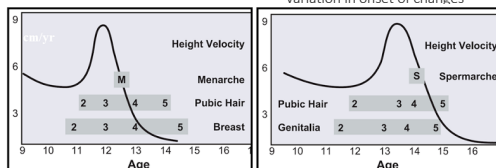
Fertile 12-18 months afterwards

Puberty takes 3-4 years but may be only 2 years or take 5-6 years

Boys - increase in penis & testicle size, pubic hair, minor voice change, spermarche, growth spurt, armpit hair, further voice changes, facial hair

Spermarche - production of viable sperm between the ages of 12 and 14

Variation in onset of changes



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Psychological impact of pubertal development

Body image preoccupation throughout adolescence

Negative perception of body

Girls less satisfied with their body than boys especially as puberty progresses; increased body fat may play a role

Boys more satisfied as puberty progresses; increased muscle mass

Boys' and girls' body image tends to become more positive as they move from the beginning to end of adolescence

Early or late maturation can increase risk to various issues

Most difficult for the **two extremes**

Early maturing girls (physical maturity does not equal cognitive maturity)

Late maturing boys (though they have stronger sense of identity in 30s)

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Brain Development

Corpus collosum thickens

Advances in information processing capacity

Levels of **neurotransmitters** change – e.g., dopamine

Maturation of **amygdala** (emotion centre within limbic system)

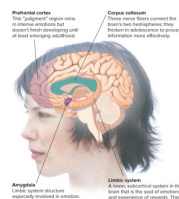
More responsive to stress and pleasurable stimulation

Prefrontal cortex maturation

Judgement, decision making, self-control

Further **synaptic pruning and myelination**

Increased focal activation & brain networks across regions



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Adolescent Sexuality

Adolescence is a time of sexual exploration and experimentation.

- Deep curiosity
- Concerned with their sexual attractiveness
- May experience vulnerability and confusion
- Sexual culture is widely available

Television, videos, magazines, music, internet, sexting

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Adolescent Sexuality

Developing a sexual identity

- Learning to manage sexual feelings
- Developing new forms of intimacy
- Learning skills to regulate sexual behaviour within social-cultural expectations
- Develop identity around sexual orientation

Diverse sexuality

- Some more anxious/relaxed than others
- Libido strong for some; less so for others
- Some sexually active; others not
- Heterosexual, gay, bisexual attraction

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Health in adolescence

Period of vulnerability

More likely to begin smoking, experiment with substances

- * 3% of 15 to 17 year-olds **smoke tobacco** (down from 14% in 2006/07)
- * 1.9% of 14 and 15 year-olds smoke tobacco (lowest ever)
- * Average starting age is 14.8 years (14 years for Maori; 16.6 years for Pasifika)
- * 57.5% of 15-17 year olds drink **alcohol**; 11.6% **hazardous drinking**
- * By age 21, 80% of young people will have used **cannabis** at least once (10% heavy dependent use)
- * In 2018, 14% of Year 10 students had used cannabis (19% in 2012)

Risk taking in sexual behaviour (STIs, pregnancy)

Mental health

Eating disorders

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Discuss

Do you have a strength based or deficit view of adolescence – is it a smooth or a troublesome time?

The adolescence view in the media and public perception can be deficit based and portrays teenagers as troublesome. Does this align with your experiences / perceptions?

Early or late development – greater psychological challenges for boys / girls? Social media influences?

Discuss in groups and be ready to report back.

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Cognitive development

Piaget's Formal
Operational Stage

Final stage where
adolescents **develop the
capacity for abstract and
scientific thinking.**



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Hypothetical-deductive reasoning

Capable of forming an abstract hypothesis

Can then deduce inferences from that hypothesis – from
possibility to reality

Vary one factor at a time, holding all other constant

Test their hypotheses systematically

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Variations in the development of formal operations

Sequential acquisition of formal operations from early
adolescence to about 15

Some adolescents and adults never achieve formal
operational thought

Differences between sociocultural contexts

Does opportunity create formal operational thinking?

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Critical thinking and idealism

Formal operational thought and advances in information processing change the way adolescents approach issues and analyse problems

- Ability to master complex issues
- Capacity to envision the future
- Tendency to be dualistic

Decision making capacity advances, though perception of risk not always applied to the self

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Flaws in adolescent thought

New capacity for abstract thought leads to a period of self focus

Elkind – adolescent egocentrism

Imaginary audience

Sense of being on stage

Personal fable

Invulnerability

Failure to attach risk to themselves



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Psychosocial Development



Erikson's Identity vs Identity Confusion stage

Marcia's Identity Statuses

Influences on identity

Family and peer relationships

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Erikson's Psychosocial Theory

A sequence of stages

involves a **psychosocial crisis** - "a state of tension that results from the discrepancies between the person's competencies at the beginning of a stage and society's expectations for behaviour at that period of life" (Newman & Newman, 2016, p.232)

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Identity vs Identity Confusion

Key turning point in life

Identity is the achievement of a coherent sense of self involving a commitment to a set of values, beliefs, and goals

Physical metamorphosis, become sexually mature

Cognitive ability to connect past, present and future in the story of 'who I am'

Psychological moratorium

- A period freedom from adult responsibilities allowing them to explore roles and identifications

A positive resolution of this stage depends on what has gone before: trust required to commit to ideals; autonomy/initiative required to explore diverse options; sense of industry required to feel competent instead of pessimistic

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Resolution along a continuum

Positive resolution of this stage involves **commitment**

Ideology

Set of values

Sexual identity

Possible career choice

The virtue of this stage is **fidelity**

Some identity confusion is necessary

Negative resolution results in **prolonged identity confusion**, isolation, aimlessness, lack of sense of purpose

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Matched social expectations

Rites of passage vs extended Western psychological moratorium

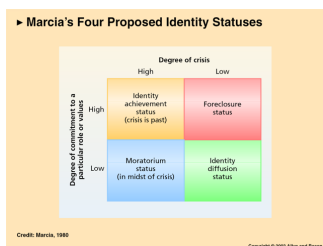
Gender intensification

Loosening of the ties to the familial microsystem

Role of the peer group

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Marcia's identity statuses



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Marcia's Definitions

Crisis – period of conscious decision making, active exploration of alternative identities

Commitment – personal investment in an occupation or system of beliefs

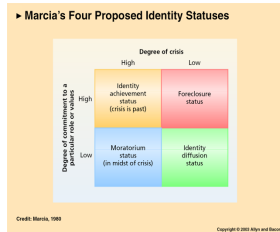
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Identity Achievement

Explored and committed to self-chosen values and goals

Crisis and commitment

Not necessarily permanent – the MAMA cycle (moratorium/achievement)



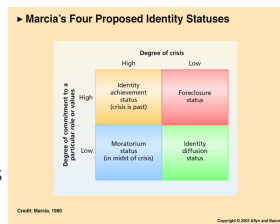
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Identity Moratorium

Exploring alternatives to find values and goals to guide life

Crisis, but no commitment yet

A necessary step towards identity achievement

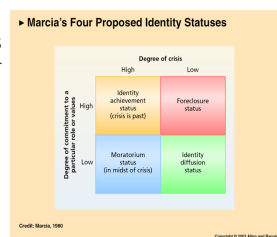


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Identity Foreclosure

Accept ready made values that have been chosen for them or are the result of an early commitment to a particular pathway

Commitment, no crisis



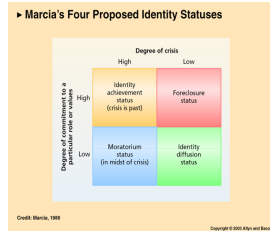
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Identity Diffusion

No commitment to goals and values, not actively seeking a direction

No crisis, no commitment

Normative in early adolescence but a concern if this status lingers and is prolonged



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Discuss

Groups – think about what it was like for you (don't have to feedback anything deep to group) and discuss what stages you went through in relation to Marcia's ideas

What about other communities / cultures in world – differences and similarities – thinking about career options – sometimes this is not an option – decided for you.

Western individualistic perspective – stages of adolescence, thoughts?

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Summary of Marcia's Identity Statuses

<https://padlet.com/kclarkhoward/pr2yerubq047dzv4>



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Moral development

Kohlberg's theory

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Read (From Santrock, 2022, pp. 240-241)

Preconventional reasoning is Kohlberg's lowest level of moral reasoning where children interpret good and bad in terms of reward and punishment.

Conventional reasoning individuals develop expectations about social roles.

Postconventional reasoning morality involves flexible thinking and is internalized

Can you think of examples?

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Family relationships

A renegotiation of parent/child roles

Balancing autonomy and attachment

Is conflict normative?

Significantly enhanced when authoritative parenting has been the norm

Can flexibly manage age appropriate boundaries while encouraging increasing autonomy

Authoritarian parenting and psychological control becomes a serious liability

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Peer relationships

Cliques and crowds

Begin as single sex but increasingly become mixed-sex
Rules of belonging and exclusion – peer conformity is a major pressure

Friendships – much more intimate and mutual, especially for girls

Protective value of friendships, role in development of identity

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End....

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